[JRD's] competence, his capability.' But Ratan would prove them wrong. Perhaps he had an advantage in being underestimated. Hidden under his affable personality was his resolutely dauntless trait. Commenting on this attribute, founder-chairman of Wipro, Azim Premji, says of Ratan: 'His grit and his absolute unwillingness to relent are his great strengths.' And Ratan went about making the changes in his quiet but determined manner.

Ratan had foreseen the liberalization a decade before it came, and this found reflection in his initial Strategic Plan. As the events in the erstwhile USSR of the mid-1980s that led to its dismemberment were already hastening economic changes in India, Ratan found it important to formulate a new version of the earlier blueprint. His aim was to prepare the group to face the emerging challenges and take advantage of new opportunities that he expected the end of the Licence Raj would spawn.

However, Ratan trod carefully in the light of the opposition to his 1983 Strategic Plan. The chief operatives of the large companies were suspicious that Ratan wanted to build an 'empire', and there was resistance to even sharing information amongst companies 'owing to strains of intercompany rivalry', commented a Harvard Business study. Even when Ratan transformed TIL 'into the group's spearhead for new high-tech ventures', the 'barons considered this a sideshow', commented *The Economist*.

Undaunted, Ratan went ahead with his goal of formulating a new version of his Strategic Plan. He constituted a corporate planning team (CPT) in TIL, with himself as the chairman. He retained Bhattacharya, who had assisted in the 1983 Plan, as its consultant. But his new plan hit an unexpected obstacle—changes in the country's political leadership.

When Rajiv Gandhi became Prime Minister in 1984, many believed it would be the beginning of a modern era. Most expected the forty-five-year-old Gandhi to win enough seats to cobble up a government in the ninth general elections, to be held in November 1989, even though his government was mired in many scandals. If he did manage, he was expected to prise open the doors to economic freedom.

Ratan was like Rajiv in some ways. Both shared a penchant for technology. They were united by strange circumstantial similarities on account of their Westernized ideals and technologically driven minds, wrote a leading Indian economic daily. The election, however, saw Vishwanath Pratap Singh emerge as the winner. The sense of urgency in revising the